between picturesque hills. A street lined with ruined market stalls and a giant tank leads to a majestic gateway. Inside is a cluster of temples, pavilions and courtyards, once dedicated to Lord Tiruvengalanatha, a form of Vishnu. Their relief carvings include quirky depictions of secular life, full of charm and mystery. They not only show dancers, musicians and saints, but also people with strange robes and hats— seemingly Arab, Turkish, Persian, and Portuguese envoys and traders—and others with unusual facial hair, beards, ornaments and poses that are a delight to behold (foreigners also appear on the Mahanavami platform in the Royal Centre and on other monuments, both secular and religious).[23] It reminds me how even the most modern and grand Hindu temples of today are so lacking in such lightness of touch and cosmopolitanism. Vijayanagar also holds the distinction of evolving the pyramidal entrance architecture of early Tamil Nadu temples into the monumental Raya Gopuram gateway, which would then spread all over the south. Here too, as in much of the world, grand architecture was used to signal imperial power to their subjects and neighbouring kingdoms.